The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

America and **Israel** launched an attack on **Iran**. Israel called the attack “pre-emptive”, claiming it would “remove threats to the state of Israel”. Several missiles struck Tehran, the capital, including the military headquarters and the offices of the supreme leader. But Iranian media said Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was in a safe, undisclosed location. Israel declared a “special and permanent state of emergency” in anticipation of an Iranian response, which an Iranian official said would be “crushing”.

President Donald Trump made an expansive case for “major combat operations”, laying out a litany of Iranian misdeeds from the country’s takeover of America’s embassy in Tehran in 1979 to its support of Hamas. He called on the Revolutionary Guard, ordinary soldiers and police to lay down their arms and receive immunity or else face “certain death”, and told the Iranian people “when we are finished, take over your government.” He warned Americans that they “may have casualties”.

Iran fired several missiles at **Israel** in response, though most seem to have been intercepted by Israel’s defence systems. **Binyamin Netanyahu**, Israel’s prime minister, warned that Israelis would need to show “endurance and fortitude” in the coming days and

called on Iranians to overthrow their government. He said that operation “Lion’s Roar” would allow Iranians to “take their destiny into their own hands”.

Meanwhile **Qatar’s** government said that it had shot down Iranian missiles over its territory, and **Bahrain’s** government said that Iranian missiles had hit a base there that had served the headquarters of the US Navy’s Fifth Fleet. Media reported earlier this week that America had moved its vessels from the base. There were also reports of explosions in Abu Dhabi, capital of the United Arab Emirates, and Kuwait.

Reza Pahlavi, the son of the last shah of Iran, released a message to Iranians urging them to take to the streets. He also called on the police and security forces to break from the clerical regime. Mr Pahlavi, who lives in America, has tried to present himself as an alternative to the regime, though Iran’s opposition movements remain wary of him.

Mr Trump ordered federal agencies to stop using **Anthropic’s** products, calling the AI lab a “radical left” company that was putting “American lives at risk”. Pete Hegseth, the secretary of war, demanded this week that Anthropic lift guardrails on its Claude models and agree to the Pentagon’s usage terms. America’s president said the Pentagon and agencies already using Anthropic’s models would phase them out over six months.

NASA overhauled its programme to put man back on the **Moon**. It had intended to send astronauts around the Moon in March, followed by a lunar landing in 2028. But on Thursday the already delayed launch of *Artemis II* was postponed again because of technical difficulties. America’s space agency is now planning another intermediary mission before attempting to land on the Moon.

Afghanistan's Taliban leaders said they were willing to negotiate with **Pakistan** to resolve the conflict between the countries. On Friday Pakistan's defence minister declared "open war" on Afghanistan after launching "counter strikes" on two Afghan cities. The attacks came in response to Afghanistan beginning "large-scale offensive operations" along the countries' border. The Taliban said their strikes were in retaliation for Pakistani attacks.

Photograph: AP

Violence resumes on Afghanistan and Pakistan’s border

“Our patience has now run out,” declared Pakistan’s defence minister, Khawaja Muhammad Asif. “Now it is open war.” The already fragile ceasefire between Pakistan and Afghanistan collapsed this week as Pakistan launched air strikes on Afghan cities including Kabul, its capital. The bombardment followed days of lethal border skirmishes.

Pakistan accuses Afghanistan’s Taliban government of harbouring and supporting its offshoot, the Pakistani Taliban, which has unleashed a wave of violence. Militant attacks in Pakistan have increased every year since the Taliban took over Afghanistan in August 2021; last year they surged to their highest level since 2015. Turkey and Qatar mediated the last ceasefire, after fighting erupted in October, and are reportedly trying to get both sides to de-escalate. The Taliban says it wants the fighting to be “resolved through dialogue”, but Pakistan says Afghanistan must make a “clear choice” between standing with terrorists and with Pakistan.

Photograph: AP

Mark Carney’s mission to trade with the world

Canada’s relationship with the United States is changing. In 2024 Canada sent more than three-quarters of its exports to its neighbour, but that number has since been sliding. Last year, as Donald Trump imposed stiff tariffs and other economic penalties in a vainglorious attempt to turn Canada into America’s 51st state, Mark Carney won his Liberal Party an unlikely fourth consecutive term.

Since then Mr Carney has been on a mission to drum up foreign investment and trade from elsewhere. He recently announced partnerships with China and Qatar. At the World Economic Forum in Davos, he exhorted like-minded middle powers to stitch together a trading coalition in the face of Mr Trump’s tariffs. This week Mr Carney landed in India, where he is expected to sign a range of deals, including to sell C$3.9bn-worth ($2.8bn) of Canadian uranium to fuel India’s nuclear-power expansion. After that he will travel to Australia and Japan. The world tour continues.

Photograph: AP

Investors’ first glimpse of Buffett-less Berkshire

Berkshire Hathaway, America’s ninth most valuable firm and last truly sprawling industrial conglomerate, has revolved around Warren Buffett since he took control of the company in 1965. His annual shareholder letter has been a must-read for investors ever since: Mr Buffett is probably American capitalism’s most successful stock-picker and certainly its most enduring narrator. But in December the 95-year-old “oracle of Omaha” retired.

On Saturday Berkshire will publish a letter penned for the first time by Greg Abel, Mr Buffett’s successor. So far there have been a few hints of how Berkshire might change after the retirement of its singular leader. Shareholders will be interested to see how Mr Abel’s prose compares. But what they really want to know are his plans for the $380bn of cash on Berkshire’s balance sheet. As interest rates come down, the cost of inaction grows. Mr Abel could spend it on deals, or return it to shareholders. Either way, shareholders are expecting answers.

Photograph: Getty Images

Humanoid robots are all play and no work

No one knows for certain how many Chinese companies are selling or plan to sell humanoid robots. By one count there are more than 100, and the list keeps growing. Over the weekend Honor, a Chinese consumer-electronics company that was once part of Huawei, a tech conglomerate, will release its own humanoid at the MWC Barcelona tech conference. The firm says the robot will help people shop.

That would be a notably practical aim. The vast majority of humanoids on the market today do little except entertain. Their dance routines can be impressive: a troupe at a recent Chinese New Year gala wowed the world. But for the industry to advance, the robots need to do more work in real-world settings—such as cleaning dishes—in order to gather training data. If Honor's humanoids can do more than martial arts, people might actually want to buy them.

Photograph: AP

Weekend profile: Ali Larijani, the man who seems to be running Iran

Editor's note: *This profile was published before the American-Israeli strikes on Iran began on February 28th.*

When is Iran's supreme leader not supreme? When he has delegated his authority to someone else. Under the constitution of the Islamic Republic of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei may devolve his power. But the octogenarian has never shed so much of it as he has done recently. Now Ali Larijani, a mandarin with an independent streak, appears to be in charge of the questions that matter most.

Mr Larijani's rise may be a sign of Mr Khamenei's loss of confidence in clerics and generals after a series of military and internal setbacks. Since the revolution of 1979, turbanned clerics have ruled Iran. Commanders from the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps managed the battlefield. But Mr Larijani is neither. Though a former guardsman born of clerical stock, he is an academic by training—a mathematician who lectured on Immanuel Kant at Tehran University. He has family in Britain and America. In a country where officials wear starched white shirts buttoned to the neck, he favours black shirts with buttons undone in the style of Johnny Cash.

Iran-watchers began detecting the change during Iran's summer war, which Israel began by targeting Iran's top commanders. Fearing he might be next, Mr Khamenei went into hiding—and has mostly remained there since. In August he formally appointed Mr Larijani as secretary of the Supreme National Security Council.

It caps a curious career. As a young official Mr Larijani was known as an austere fundamentalist. As culture minister and then head of state broadcasting, he marginalised reformists and aired their forced confessions. By the mid-2000s, however, he had edged towards pragmatism. He took part in early nuclear talks with Europe, opposed the rigged re-election of the hardline populist president, Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, and helped secure ratification of the 2015 nuclear deal. For this flexibility he has paid a price: hardliners accused him of corruption, in effect forced his brother out from the judiciary and twice barred him from running for president.

Does Mr Larijani's return herald Iran's shift from a theocracy towards something more technocratic? As a regime careerist, he will do little to assuage Iranians enraged by last month's bloody suppression of protests. Yet few others possess the pedigree to coax the regime's bastions of power into line—or to persuade Western negotiators that the regime is serious about burying the hatchet with America. If Iran is on the cusp of becoming a post-Islamic republic, Mr Larijani might yet be the regime's choice for supreme leader.

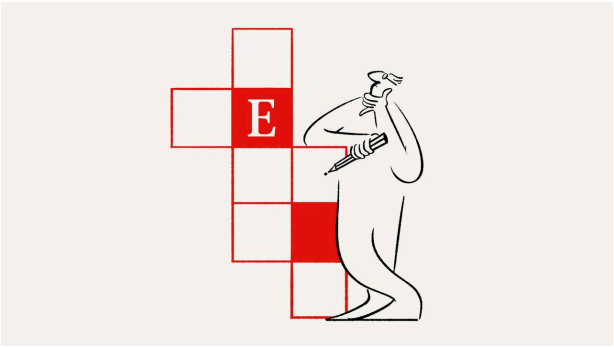

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - As war minister, he gets hydrogen explosion (7)

2 across - Zagreb resident travels around Belgium as a tumbler (7)

3 across - Welsh tribe ripe, in part, for reverse renaissance (7)

1 down - Misanthrope swallows nice new ball, spinning—and his own kind (8,6)

Straight clues

1 across - He's taking the war to Anthropic (7)

2 across - A well-known PDF reader (7)

3 across - "A ------- of hope", promises Donald Trump, "in our neglected inner cities" (7)

1 down - An antihero with a grisly allure (8,6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Anneli Hildeman, Brussels, Belgium

Ozlem Sumnu, Barcelona, Spain

Bruce Fink, Honolulu, Hawaii, America

They all gave the correct answers of: Henry Kissinger, Woodrow Wilson, Martin Luther King junior, Linus Pauling and Al Gore. The theme is that they were all American winners of the Nobel peace prize.

The questions were:

Monday: Which American statesman who was secretary of state under Richard Nixon died in 2023 at the age of 100?

Tuesday: Which American statesman helped create the League of Nations, although he failed to persuade America to join?

Wednesday: In America, the third Monday of January is a federal holiday named after which civil-rights activist?

Thursday: Which prominent scientist, who helped explain that sickle cell anemia was caused by an abnormal protein, became an advocate for taking high doses of vitamin C?

Friday: Who wrote “An Inconvenient Truth”, a book about climate change?

I’m glad you like adverbs — I adore them; they are the only qualifications I really much respect.

Henry James